11 Political Divisions of East India

Topics covered

- Summary of information
- Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha, Assam

Find Bihar, West Bengal, Odisha and Assam in the map. Use the political map on page 72 to help you.

- Which neighbouring country is also on the plain?
- Which state is in the easternmost part of the plain?

The great northern plain stretches to the eastern part of India. It has several Indian states. It also has Bangladesh, our neighbour on the east.

In this part of the plain, the summer is very hot, the monsoon rains are heavy and the winter is cool and pleasant. The table gives you a quick view of information about these states.

State	Capital and some cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Bihar	Patna—capital, Bodh Gaya, Bhagalpur	Ganga, Kosi, Son	Some deciduous forests	Rice, sugar cane, lychee	Farming, silk weaving
West Bengal	Kolkata—capital, Darjiling, Durgapur	Hugli, Tista	Conifers, deciduous trees, mountain plants, mangrove forests	Rice, jute, tea	Farming, fishing, handicrafts, and working in factories and offices

State	Capital and some cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Odisha	Bhubaneshwar —capital, Cuttack, Rourkela, Puri	Mahanadi, Subarnarekha	Forests with deciduous trees and bamboo	Rice, pulses, oilseeds, coconuts	Farming, fishing, handicrafts, weaving and working in offices and factories
Assam	Dispur—capital, Guwahati, Dibrugarh, Jorhat	Brahmaputra	Evergreen and deciduous trees, grassland, orchids, ferns and bamboo forests	Rice, tea, jute, fruit	Farming, working in tea gardens, silk weaving and working in the oil refineries

BIHAR

Capital and other cities: Patna is the capital of Bihar and lies on the banks of the Ganga. Bodh Gaya is an important Buddhist town and many people come to pray here. Bhagalpur is also another big town known for its silk.

Gandhi Setu across the river Ganga—a very long bridge connecting Patna to north Bihar

Rivers: The Ganga flows through Bihar. Two of its tributaries, Kosi and Son, meet the Ganga at Patna. Together they make the land very fertile with silt when they flood.

The ruins of the ancient university at Nalanda—students from many countries used to study here.

Natural vegetation: The natural vegetation of Bihar consists of deciduous forests, but most of the land has now been cleared of forests to grow crops. There are some forested areas in the **foothills,** the low hills at the base of the mountains.

Crops: Rice and sugar cane are the main crops grown. Lychee, a delicious fruit, is also grown here.

Occupation: Most people live in villages and are farmers. Silk weaving is a handicraft industry here.

WEST BENGAL

Capital and other cities: Kolkata is the capital of West Bengal. Durgapur is an industrial city that has a steel plant. Darjiling is a popular hill town in the north.

Rivers: The Hugli, a branch of the Ganga, flows along the capital city. The Tista in north Bengal is another important river.

The Victoria Memorial in Kolkata is a beautiful building of white marble built during British rule in memory of Queen Victoria.

Natural vegetation: The northern mountainous part of the state has coniferous trees and mountain plants. A little further down there are forests of deciduous trees. In the plains, the natural vegetation has been cleared for fields to grow crops. The coastal areas near the sea have mangrove forests.

The Howrah Bridge or the Rabindra Setu over the river Hugli is over 70 years old!

Did you Know?

The forests of the Sundarbans lie in both India and Bangladesh, with the greater part being in Bangladesh. These are the only mangrove forests in the world where tigers are found.

Crops: Rice is grown in plenty in the plains. Jute is cultivated in the wetter regions. There are many tea plantations in the hilly regions.

Occupation: Farming, tea growing, fishing, handicrafts, like cotton and silk weaving, are the main occupations of the people in the villages. Those in the cities work in offices or factories.

ODISHA

Capital and other cities: Bhubaneshwar is the capital of Odisha, a state that lies partly on the plains and partly in the plateau region. Cuttack is a large city close by. Another important coastal city is Puri, known for its temples. Rourkela has a huge steel plant.

Rivers: The rivers Mahanadi and Subarnarekha flow through Odisha. Lake Chilika is the largest saltwater lake in India where thousands of birds migrate from some colder countries.

A stone chariot wheel at the Konark Sun Temple, near Puri

Natural vegetation: Odisha has thicker forests in the north than the south. These forests have bamboo and deciduous trees like teak and rosewood.

Crops: Rice, pulses and oilseeds are grown in the plains. Coastal areas have coconut trees as they grow well there.

Occupation: Farming and fishing are major occupations in the rural areas. People in the cities work in offices and factories. Many people are also engaged in handicrafts and silk weaving.

Some beaches in Odisha have Olive Ridley turtles coming up to lay eggs.

ASSAM

Capital and other cities: Dispur is the capital city, which is near Guwahati. Dibrugarh and Jorhat are other important towns.

Rivers: The Brahmaputra is a huge, wide river flowing through Assam. It has only four bridges for people to cross the river. People therefore use a **ferry** to go to and from across the river. During the monsoons the river overflows its banks very often flooding the areas around it.

Two one-horned rhinoceros in the Kaziranga National Park in Assam

Natural vegetation: The Assam valley—surrounded by the mountains and hills—is plain land with evergreen trees, deciduous trees, grasslands, bamboo plants, orchid flowers and **ferns**.

Crops: Rice and tea are major crops in the state. Jute and fruits like pineapple and oranges are also grown.

Occupation: Farming and working in the tea gardens are the main occupations. People also work in the oil **refineries** as the state has underground oil and gas. Weaving of a special kind of silk called 'muga' is also an important occupation.

Discuss

TP SI

Bring pieces of handicrafts from these states and share details about them in class.

Think and answer

SI

Tea bushes are cut so that they are all the same, low height (see picture). Why do you think this is so?

Only the topmost tender leaves of the tea plant are plucked—usually women do this work.

Values and Life Skills

Rivers are useful for people in many ways, but they are being polluted. What can we do to keep them clean?

REMEMBER

1. The states of Bihar, West Bengal, Assam and Odisha lie on the eastern part of the northern plain.
2. The soil is fertile as the rivers bring down silt.
3. Rice is grown in all the states.
4. Farming is an important occupation.

NEW WORDS

Foothills	hills or low mountains at the base of a higher mountain or range of mountains
Ferry	a boat or ship that carries people, vehicles and goods across a river
Fern	a flowerless plant with feathery leaves
Refinery	an industry where something is purified

EXERCISES

A. Name the following.

1. An ancient university which had students from different countries .....
2. A monument of white marble .....
3. A temple that is famous for its stone wheels .....
4. A town that has steel mills .....
5. A national park famous for its one-horned rhinoceros .....

B. Choose the correct answer.

1. Rice grows well in the plains as **the land is rocky**/**the rivers make the soil fertile**.
2. Tea is grown in **all the four states**/**Assam and West Bengal**.
3. **Bihar**/**Assam**/**Odisha** has Buddhist temples.
4. An important occupation in places close to the rivers and seas is **handicrafts**/**fishing**.
5. Lake Chilika is **the largest saltwater lake in India**/**a very large sea**.

C. Sort me out.

Here are the names of some cities. Sort them into the correct boxes.

Jorhat, Durgapur, Puri, Bhagalpur, Cuttack, Dibrugarh, Darjiling, Bodh Gaya

Bihar	West Bengal	Assam	Odisha

D. Unscramble the names of these rivers.

Write a line about them.

LIGUH, AAAMRHBPRTU, SIKO, HAANADIM

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What is the occupation of most people in these states of east India?
2. Why is the land around Patna very fertile?
3. Why is natural vegetation so varied in West Bengal?
4. What trees do the forests of Odisha have?
5. What kind of natural vegetation does Assam have?

THINGS TO DO

TP SI

A. In a group

Divide yourselves into four groups—one for each state. Put together all the interesting information from these states in an attractive manner—like a tourist poster inviting people to that state. Put up the posters in class.

B. On your Own

1. Find out where the tea used in your house is grown.
2. Collect wrappers or packaging of Assam tea and Darjiling tea. List the brand names of each kind of tea in two columns.

TP C. Picture study

Find out more about the following and discuss the information in class.

1. Sunderbans

2. The vast Brahmaputra

3. Silk weaving in all these states

WEBLINK

How deltas are formed: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A47ythEcz74 (accessed on 27 July 2017)